

Legal protection guide for freelancers to invoice, contract, and collect payment — Action Checklist

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BUILD WRITTEN AGREEMENTS

- ☐ **Build Written Agreements:** Write down and send your client a specific scope document listing exactly what deliverables are included and what is excluded before starting any project. Without documented scope, both you and the client have equally valid but conflicting assumptions.
- ☐ **Build Written Agreements:** Create a standard change order template with fields for describing the change, additional hours required, and any price adjustment needed before you start additional work. Verbal change requests easily get lost and turn into unpaid work.
- ☐ **Build Written Agreements:** Send your scope document and change order template to each client for written sign-off via email before you begin work. Email sign-off creates a timestamped record that protects you when scope disputes arise later.
- ☐ **Build Written Agreements:** Store all signed scope documents and change orders in a dedicated cloud folder organized by client so you can find and share them within minutes whenever needed. Accessible records make payment disputes solvable instead of stressful.

SET PAYMENT PROTECTIONS

- ☐ **Set Payment Protections:** Write out specific payment terms including your due dates, late fees, what happens on non-payment, and dispute resolution steps and include them in every contract. Operating without explicit terms leaves you relying entirely on the client's goodwill.
 - ☐ **Set Payment Protections:** Add a late payment penalty clause to your contract that specifies a percentage or dollar amount charged for each week an invoice goes unpaid past the due date. Automatic penalties create financial consequences that motivate clients to prioritize your payment.
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- ❑ **Set Payment Protections:** Set up a simple tracking system using a spreadsheet or app to log every invoice you send, when it was due, and when payment arrived. Tracking ensures you notice overdue payments immediately instead of discovering them months later.
- ❑ **Set Payment Protections:** Send your first overdue payment reminder automatically on the day payment is due and follow with escalating messages on day 7 and day 14 if payment remains outstanding. Consistent follow-up turns invoices that would otherwise disappear into paid ones.

CREATE DELIVERY PROOF

- ❑ **Create Delivery Proof:** Send all final deliverables through email or a project management platform that automatically timestamps when files were sent and delivered to each recipient. Timestamped delivery records provide concrete evidence of when work was completed.
- ❑ **Create Delivery Proof:** Request explicit written confirmation from your client acknowledging receipt of deliverables before you consider the project complete. Client acknowledgment creates documented proof that protects you if they later claim they never received work.
- ❑ **Create Delivery Proof:** Build an evidence file containing all project emails, signed agreements, change orders, invoices, and delivery confirmations organized by client in a single accessible location. Having everything organized makes assembling your case quick when disputes arise.
- ❑ **Create Delivery Proof:** Review your current client list and identify which projects have solid delivery confirmations versus which ones leave you vulnerable to he-said-she-said disputes. Knowing your gaps helps you prioritize which active projects need immediate documentation.

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